

Show Me the Receipts — Session Record

Giving USA 2026 → The Pipeline Argument, the Napkin, and Robert's Return

Session dated 063026–070326 · Connects the 2026 sector data to the pipeline-crisis synthesis, a new public-facing graphic language, and the first One Minute Manager chapter

What This Session Produced

This session took delivery of the Giving USA 2026 and FEP Q4 2025 releases, corrected a stale figure that had been riding in the sector-trends graphic, and built the **pipeline-crisis synthesis** on top of the verified numbers: the record year is a harvest planted five to ten years ago, the base where the next harvest should be planted is going bare, and concentration is therefore not a separate problem from retention but the same promise failure one cycle downstream. The synthesis was deliberately kept **off the graph and in the text** (measured series on the graphic; causal inference in prose), which produced a two-register output set: a data brief of record, three generations of graphic, three LinkedIn drafts, a Hugo-ready Field Note, and the first Robert story in the One Minute Manager frame.

Sector Data of Record

Giving USA 2026 (data year 2025), current dollars. Total giving \$617.20B, first year over \$600B, +5.7% current / +3.0% inflation-adjusted [Direct]. Individuals \$394.20B, +4.1% current, now 64% of total — down from ~80% in 1985 [Direct]. Bequests \$62.19B, +19.7%, strongest source growth [Direct]. Foundations the lone declining source, –16.2% off a 2024 high [Direct]. Giving USA measures dollars by source and recipient; it carries **no donor-count or acquisition metric** — those live in FEP, and attribution must not blur the two.

FEP Q4 2025 (data year 2025). Donor count –3.6%, fifth consecutive annual decline, rate of decline slowing since 2022 [Direct]. Dollars +5.0%, strongest in five years, driven almost entirely by Major and Supersize donors [Direct]. Overall retention **rose** slightly, 43.1% → 43.3% [Direct]. New-donor retention flat near 19% (19.4% prior cycle) [Direct]. Acquisition essentially flat, ~32% [Direct].

Corrections of Record

1. The retention mis-vintage. The prior graphic (063025 version) plotted retention falling to 42.9% with a "5th straight yearly drop" annotation. That figure was FEP Q4 **2024**, superseded. Retention did not fall this cycle; it rose to 43.3%. The line in its fifth year of decline is the **donor count**, not the retention rate. All current assets carry the correction; the data brief documents the supersession.

2. The ten-year median. The claim "the median major gift relationship runs about a decade" is **not traceable to a source** — the session's search found no published median. It is false precision that entered the record as a tidy summary of a looser, well-supported pattern. Defensible phrasing of record: **"the better part of a decade."** Stronger citable anchors identified for future use: the second-gift hinge data (roughly 14% of first-time donors give again the next year; a second gift nearly doubles the odds of a third; by the third gift about two-thirds continue) and Evertrue's finding that the average age of first-time major donors has risen from 55 to 66 over two decades. All session outputs use the softened phrasing.

3. "Fewer donors than 2015" (hero band). Directionally sound but coded [Synthesis]: FEP publishes year-over-year changes, not an indexed decade headcount. Fallback phrasing if challenged: "fewer donors, five years running."

The Pipeline-Crisis Synthesis [Synthesis]

Major gifts are grown, not acquired; the relationships behind them are built over years. Today's record Major/Supersize dollars are therefore the harvest of small and mid gifts planted five to ten years ago. The base being planted now is eroding (micro donors –9%; first-year retention at the ~19% floor), while acquisition is flat — so the pipeline is not emptying at acquisition but **at the front door, after the first gift**. Concentration is the delayed face of the same front-door promise failure. Distillation of record: *A retention problem is a promise problem. A major gift pipeline is a retention problem with a ten-year fuse.*

The causal attribution (first-year donors lost specifically to unkept intake promises) remains SMTR's reading, not a measured FEP finding [Synthesis]. The Promise-at-Intake Record is the instrument built to make that attribution testable; instruments remain at legibility-demonstrated, validity-untested.

The double-loop articulation. Single-loop: "how do we get donors back?" — retention treated as donor behavior, the donor as the variable. Double-loop: **"what did we promise them when we took their gift, and did we keep it?"** — the institution as the variable. The structural point: every CRM tracks what the donor did; none has a field for what the institution promised, so the failure only surfaces later, disguised as a lapse, untraceable. The sector is optimizing the number its systems can see and is blind to the one that causes it. This is a measurement-architecture (governing-variable) problem, which is what makes the question double-loop rather than a better tactic.

Doctrine Settled This Session

- **Measured series on the graph; causal inference in the text.** The pipeline argument was deliberately kept off the graphic so every plotted line remains a real series and the projection lives where the reasoning can be shown.

- **The graphic stops the scroll; the post instills the common sense.** Division of labor confirmed and then superseded in practice by the napkin: a graphic that *doesn't* try to stop the show, whose rough register matches a personal story.
- **A napkin holds one idea.** The napkin carries the pipeline argument only; everything else is the prose's job. A napkin makes an argument; it does not impersonate a measurement — even so, its figures obey the CEF.
- **Two-lane architecture for distribution.** Brief on the platform, argument on owned property; LinkedIn posts function as pointers into the long-form home once the site restructure lands.
- **The process is the champion** (ratified). In Robert stories the viewpoint character is the camera; the instrument is the protagonist. The climax belongs to the CRM's missing field, not to anyone winning an argument.
- **Concentration needs no promise/fulfillment solution in itself;** it enters SMTR only through the pipeline synthesis. Resisting a forced SMTR frame on concentration was noted as drift-sensor discipline working.

LinkedIn Reach Diagnosis

The foundational single/double-loop post: 44 impressions, 15 members reached, zero engagement, 98% in-network. Verdict: **pure reach problem** — at 15 reached the content is untested, not failed, and the earlier "doesn't travel in a brief" finding is *not* confirmed by this post (the brief never entered a room). Consequences: the personal-vs-professional voice A/B test cannot produce signal at this reach; distribution work precedes further posting. Priority order: substantive comments on high-traffic sector posts (dialogue is where the framework survives — comments are dialogue), deliberate network building in AFP/CFRE circles, recruiting a first-hour comment bench, then reposting the restructured argument off the news cycle. No external links in post bodies; site link goes in a first comment.

The Deliverables, in Build Order

1. SMTR_SectorDataBrief_GivingUSA2026_063026.docx

Consolidated source-of-record brief: both releases, CEF-coded claims, citation trail, and the documented supersession of the 42.9% retention figure. Filed to project.

2. SMTR_Sector_Trends_Decade_063026.png (three generations)

(a) Corrected calm four-panel; (b) bold hero-band version — dark navy-to-purple band, \$617B in gold, "More Money. Fewer Donors. Held-but-Hollow.", charts as evidence strip; (c) final: two-line retention panel overlaying **new-donor retention (~19% floor)** beneath overall retention (43.3%), the gap between the lines carrying "held-but-hollow" visually. Synthesis box heading: "What the three findings say together." Kick line: "A retention

problem is a promise problem — and the first-year donor is where the promise is never written down."

3. SMTR_Napkin_Pipeline_070226.png

Napkin-sketch graphic: wobbly pyramid, "grown ~a decade" arrow, scratched-out base (micro -9%; 4 of 5 first-timers), circled question "what's being planted NOW?", double-loop question written sideways in the margin, coffee ring, brand-cream napkin with nav-blue ink. Glen's AI-textured regeneration is the keeper aesthetically but **garbled the statistics** (the -9% is illegible; the sideways question reads "whdid we promise them") — must be fixed before any public use.

4. LinkedIn drafts (three)

(a) Withstand read of the record ("the good number is the warning"); (b) pipeline companion; (c) final napkin story — hook "I grabbed a napkin," closes on "What would you write on yours?" as the engagement mechanism. Composite-scene exposure noted: the coffee scene reads as lived; habitual-framing fix offered ("When a colleague asks me... this is what I draw") at Glen's discretion.

5. FieldNote_070226_WhatsBeingPlantedNow.md

Hugo-ready long-form Field Note (front matter included): the napkin narrated, colleague's single-loop reflex answered by flat acquisition, double-loop question arriving sideways in the margin, "She kept the napkin" close, composite-scene disclosure block with sourcing. Filed to project.

6. Robert_PerformanceImprovementPlan_070226.md + LinkedIn cut

First One Minute Manager chapter. Sarah (ED/Artistic Director) forwards the record as an innocent PIP ("We were flat. Monday?"); Robert declines the defensive email (flashpoint lesson honored); napkin teaches; Sarah translates through her craft ("Curtain at eight is a promise... I don't fix that with a bigger marquee"); climax is the CRM failing to answer "what did we promise them" — the missing field as reveal; Sarah's flip: "We've been grading the wrong performer"; close on ten promises, owners, dates, thirty days — the Promise-at-Intake Record born at the theater. Full version filed (Workbook-chapter length, notebook entry and wall card intact); LinkedIn cut ~2,850 characters (flashpoint callback, notebook, and card cut; "(FEP data)" removed from the acquisition line — cite FEP in a comment reply if challenged).

The Robert Canon (established this session)

Robert: Director of Development at a theater company. Sarah: his ED and Artistic Director — an intelligent outsider whose single-loop reads arrive innocently; her turns come

through her own craft, not through fundraising logic. Inherited conventions honored: the notebook entry close, the flashpoint lesson ("when someone names a tension, it's an invitation"), the collaborative pattern from the grant-rejection arc. The theater company is the natural host of the first working promise registry, consistent with the project's prior note that one working registry at a theatre company outweighs advocacy.

Continuity collision flagged, unresolved: the corpus now holds two Sarahs — Robert's ED and the eleven-year fundraiser in "What a Room Can't Trace." Robert's Sarah became load-bearing this session; if either renames, it is likely the other. Glen to decide.

Website / Hugo State

Decision: restructure ShowMeReceipts.org blog-first (Field Notes as front page; the current essay becomes Start Here/About). Hugo selected; approach is **port the existing design into custom templates**, not adopt a theme. Discrepancy found: the deployed site is newer than the project's index.html (live nav carries Field Notes and a "Trace One Failure" tool absent from the project copy) — deployed files need to come into the project before any redesign. Install state on the Acer 514 Chromebook (Crostoni): apt delivered Hugo v0.111.3 (old but functional); an amd64 .deb upgrade attempt broke the install; **ARM architecture suspected** — diagnosis pending via `dpkg --print-architecture`; if arm64, the fix is the linux-arm64 .deb (plain build is sufficient if extended isn't published for arm64 — the port uses hand-written CSS, no SASS).

On the Horizon

- Fix the napkin image's garbled statistics before public use (regenerate with explicit text, or composite clean SVG text over the textured version).
- Resolve the two-Sarahs collision.
- Resolve Hugo/ARM on the Chromebook; pull deployed site files into the project; begin the template port with the napkin Field Note as inaugural front-page post.
- Recruit the first-hour comment bench; begin the comments-first distribution phase.
- Decide the composite-scene framing on the napkin LinkedIn post before it ships.
- Hero-band "fewer donors than 2015" phrasing: keep or swap to "fewer donors, five years running."
- Update the Sargeant-adjacent pipeline claim across older documents to the "better part of a decade" phrasing wherever the ten-year median may have propagated.